

EPFL HUMAN RESEARCH ETHICS COMMITTEE

RESEARCH PROTOCOL AND ETHICAL ISSUES - SECTION C2

This document needs to be uploaded in section C2 of the on-line HREC application form

Name applicants	Rens Chazottes and Robin Huguenot-Noël
Title project	Climate Policy and Just Transition: A Comparative Study of Worker Support (JUST-CLIP)

Please describe your research protocol, incl. study design / research methodology (e.g. observational, survey research, experimental). Give details of any samples or measurements to be taken.

Project rational and research questions

Climate change and decarbonization imperatives have led governments across the world to adopt policies aimed at reducing the economic value of carbon-intensive assets, such as coal mines, fossil fuel-powered and vehicles, and aircraft reliant on traditional jet fuel. Decarbonisation policies, however, rarely affect asset holders alone. More often than not, the 'stranding' of such assets comes at a cost for the social fabric of established communities – from the fragmentation of local social structures to the contestation of democratic structures by anti-climate parties (as observed in the US, Argentina, or the Netherlands). From a political economy perspective, this context raises two major questions:

1. Can carbon-intensive asset-stranding policies be designed in a way that enhances (rather than undermines) local community ties?
2. To what extent can political intermediaries (such as trade unions) embedded in these sectors initiate, cope with, and react to large-scale shifts in relative valuations?

Study population and sampling method

To answer these questions, we field a conjoint experiment with workers from sectors likely to be significantly affected by decarbonization efforts: manufacturing, heavy industry (including chemicals and materials), the automobile, and the aviation sector. We conduct a comparative study of multiple European countries including France, Germany, Pologne, Italy, and Spain where unions play distinct roles in the bargaining process.

Overall, in each country, we aim to recruit two samples of 1,500 workers from industries likely to be impacted by the climate transition in each country. For the first sample, we will undertake a snowballing procedure contacting the main unions and employers in each sector asking to share our survey with their workers. For the second sample, we will recruit participants through social network adds (such as facebook).

The survey will be administered online via the Qualtrics platform and distributed through union and employer networks in the targeted sectors or via social network adds. To encourage participation, the survey will include an incentive: respondents will be entered into a lottery to win a €200 voucher.

We will collect participants personal information such as their e-mail address to field another survey, six months later, to understand the dynamic nature of political preferences.

Methodology – conjoint experiment

A conjoint experiment is a survey method in which respondents are shown pairs of policy packages (each combining different features) and asked to choose the one they find more acceptable, allowing researchers to identify the relative importance of each feature in decision-making.

Prompt

“To address global warming, the government has adopted a five-year plan to reduce emissions in high-polluting sectors by phasing out fossil fuels. Your company is directly affected by this plan. It is expected that up to 30% of the workforce may lose their jobs over the next five years. To reduce the negative impact on workers and local communities, the government is considering different support packages.

In the following task, you will see four pairs of possible hypothetical support packages. Each proposal includes a combination of features such as the level of financial compensation, job training, and investment in your region. For each pair, please select the option you find more acceptable. There are no right or wrong answers—we are simply interested in your opinion.”

Attributes and Levels

1. Financial compensation for job loss
 - Monthly payments equal to 60% of current salary
 - Monthly payments equal to 80% of current salary
 - Monthly payments equal to 100% of current salary
2. Training
 - No training support
 - Basic training for entry-level jobs (e.g., logistics, care work, retail)
 - Advanced training for skilled professions (e.g., technician, electrician, IT support)
3. Job support
 - Regular public employment service
 - Personalised job-search assistance
 - Temporary job placement guarantee
4. Community investment
 - No investment
 - Infrastructure (transport, broadband)
 - Green programmes (renewables, environmental restoration)
 - Social services (hospitals, childcare)
5. Location of community investment
 - In your municipality
 - In your province (departement)
 - In your region
6. Union position
 - No union position
 - Union opposes plan
 - Union supports plan
7. Climate NGO positions
 - No Climate NGO position

- Climate NGO opposes plan
- Climate NGO supports plan

8. Employer position

- No employer position
- Employer opposes plan
- Employer supports plan

Measurement strategy

For the conjoint experiment we use two main dependent variable:

- **Main outcome** – a dummy indicating the preferred policy (all sample, + a third of the sample only)
- (secondary outcome for robustness check) Respondents are asked to determine how strongly they feel about their preference from 1-3.
- **Secondary outcome** – a dummy indicating which policy is believed to benefit the most workers overall ? (a third of the sample)
- **Tertiary outcome** - a dummy indicating which policy is believed to benefit the most your community ? (another third of the sample)

Other survey items

Our survey includes questions regarding socio-demographic characteristics, political affiliation and opinions, political activities, relationships with unions and opinions towards unions, job security.

Please describe the ethical issues linked to your research project and how they will be addressed.

Ethical issues

The survey targets workers in sectors directly impacted by climate policy (e.g., coal, heavy industry, aviation), that is: groups that may face real job losses or political marginalization. Given the personal and professional risks associated with expressing opinions about union positions, government policies, or company practices, any breach of confidentiality could harm participants' employment status, union relationships, or community standing.

Mitigation strategy

1. Informed Consent: Participants will be presented with a clear and comprehensive informed consent form at the beginning of the online survey. The form will explain the purpose of the study, the nature of the tasks involved, and the expected duration of participation. It will emphasize that participation is entirely voluntary and that respondents may withdraw at any time without explanation or penalty. The consent form will also describe the data collected, its use for academic research only, and how pseudo-anonymity and confidentiality will be safeguarded. Participants must affirmatively agree to these terms before proceeding with the survey.

2. Anonymity and Data Protection: To ensure participants' pseudo-anonymity, identifiable information (e-mail collected for follow-up survey waves) will be stored in a separate files from the data and in a password protected folder. No other personal information will be collected. Data will be stored securely on encrypted servers compliant with GDPR and institutional data protection protocols. Access to raw data will be limited to the core research team. In all publications and reports, findings will be presented in aggregate form, and subgroup analyses will only be reported where the number of responses is sufficient to prevent potential re-identification.

3. Gatekeeper Engagement (Unions and Employers): Given the sector-specific focus of the study, the survey will be distributed through trade unions and employer networks in the relevant industries.

Gatekeepers will be informed in writing that the study is independent, confidential, and anonymous. They will be asked to distribute the survey link without monitoring who chooses to participate. No individual-level responses or identifying information will be shared with union or employer networks at any point.